when he found a camp follower performing namaaz ‘in the manner of imitating theologians’, whether he was to be ‘forbidden’ or ‘left in his way’, the prince was told that such a person was not to be forced to abandon his practices, but instead deserved ‘admonition’ to bring him to ‘the path of reason’. These instances show that the court was moving in a direction that would have been uncongenial to a man of Aziz Koka’s persuasions. And yet, there is enough evidence to suppose that it was not simply the matter of religious innovations that caused Aziz Koka to take such a drastic step in 1593. After all, a man of his talent, wealth, and stature could have continued unmolested in his jagirs and Akbar would never have tried to impose any change in his beliefs. It was rather that Aziz Koka believed that there were those at court who were advancing at his expense, who were using their position to influence the Padshah against him and his family, the Ataka Khail, and these persons were, namely, Abu’l Fazl and Faizi.

From the time that the ‘dagh’ had been instituted, Aziz Koka had been vocal about the injustice in undermining the old nobility in favour of persons he would have judged much more suspect. In an earlier letter written to Akbar, Aziz Koka did not only criticize the Padshah’s religious beliefs but he also accused Akbar of raising Abu’l Fazl and Faizi to the position of the Caliphs Usman and Ali. ‘Some of the hypocrites about Court,’ agreed Badauni when writing of Aziz Koka’s fall, ‘told tales of him and got him removed from his post.’ In his letter Aziz Koka fulminated that ‘his enemies had influenced the Emperor’s mind against him and sought his ruin’. ‘Slanders and calumnies’, he stormed, had been brought to the royal ears by ‘one who is the guide of the world-adorning opinion’, by which Aziz Koka was clearly implicating Abu’l Fazl. If somewhat tactless and undiplomatic, Aziz Koka remained courageous in the strength of his beliefs and in his ability, almost unique at court, to speak his mind without ever parsing his words.

Aziz Koka boarded the *Ilahi*, a ship that he had had built when he was Governor of Surat, and set sail for Mecca in sufficiently grandiose style. He left with his six younger sons, six daughters, his wives, about one hundred attendants and a great deal of treasure. When Akbar heard what Aziz Koka had done, wrote Abu’l Fazl, the Padshah, though saddened, forgave him for this impertinent disobedience. ‘Inasmuch as I have trod the path of peace with Jews and Christians and others, how can I rise up against my own protegé?’ said Akbar. ‘I so love Aziz that though he shows evil thoughts, we